

CONGRESS

Andhra Pradesh

A PRABHAKAR RAO



- The ruling Congress and the Opposition TDP are indulging in competitive populism. While Chief Minister Rajasekhara Reddy (L) wants to revive the rice-at-Rs 2-per-kg scheme, TDP's winning slogan in 1983, Chandrababu Naidu is promising nine hours of free power per day to farmers.
- Congress promises eight million power connections for the weaker sections; TDP counters with a cut in domestic power tariff for the poor.
- Congress promises grocery and toiletry items under the public distribution system; TDP says it will give saris and dhotis at subsidised rates to the needy.

country's workforce in the unorganised sector, it was a significant statement whose only objective was to woo voters. Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav has used every platform—railway or otherwise—to ward off early polls. In the next few weeks, his itinerary is likely to include a foundation-laying spree in his home state of Bihar. Among the 13 new railway projects he is supposed to inaugurate are two locomotive units and six new railway lines, with a total investment of over Rs 2,500 crore—something that might come in handy when elections are finally announced.

The many bonanzas target different sections of people. In mid-September, a Group of Ministers met in a hurry and approved soft loans of Rs 2,000 crore for sugar mills, besides an additional Rs 420-crore subsidy for sugar exports. The Labour Ministry has proposed raising the bonus ceiling for organised labour from the current minimum of Rs 2,500 per month to Rs 3,500, a move that could bring cheer to over a crore of workers in both the government and the private sectors. While the eligibility limit for bonus entitlement has been raised from Rs 3,500 per month to Rs 10,000, construction workers will also be brought under the net of the Payment of Bonus Act. For working women, the ministry has announced changes in maternity benefits.

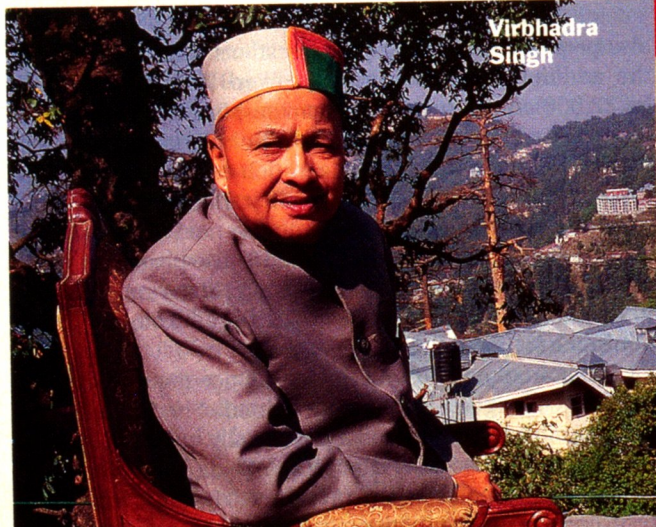
In its strongest ever bid to regain the vote of the minorities, the Government has introduced a slew of measures for students from these communities. The measures, which were announced in Parliament by Minister of Minority Affairs A.R. Antulay, who said that the Government would bear all the expenses of students from minority communities who secured admission in any of the 50 pre-identified institutions of excellence, including the IITs and the IIMS, on merit. A scholarship scheme for 20,000 students pursuing technical and professional courses, a special literacy drive in areas with a substantial minority population, a madarsa modernisation programme and extension of the midday meal scheme were also announced.

Another huge sop came on October 9, with the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs declaring an upward revision of the minimum support price (MSP) of wheat from Rs 850 per quintal to Rs 1,000 for domestic traders. It seems

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Himachal Pradesh

- Large-scale recruitments in government departments, contrary to the party's 2006 promise of downsizing the administration.
- Personal Accident Scheme extended to ad hoc, contractual, part-time and daily wagers in government and public bodies.
- Farmers exempted from stamp duty and registration fee on loans for agriculture and allied activities from state-owned banks.



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